

Win.INI

BY FRED LANGA

Would everyone who likes Program Manager please raise your hand?

I wish I could see you now. My hand's up, but I don't know how many others feel the same way.

A lot of vendors must think we all hate the thing. Hardly a week goes by without someone plunking down YAPMR—yet another Program Manager replacement—on my desk. I wish there were half as much activity in Windows-based comm packages or databases.... Instead, it feels like someone secretly signed me up for the Windows Shell-of-the-Month Club.

It's not that ProgMan is perfect. Far from it: *WINDOWS Magazine* columnist John Ruley has made an eloquent case for a more Mac-like Program Manager. He'd like to see better integration of the current ProgMan and FileMan functions. (Rumor has it that Windows 4.0 may have just such an integrated front end.) I think John's right.

There are at least three other things wrong with ProgMan. For one, it's absolutely unforgivable that a so-called graphical environment sets up all your different program groups with identical little default icons. Graphical? No way! You have to read the icon titles to tell one group from another. To me, this is Windows' single most glaring visual design failure.

Third-party add-on software such as GrpIcon (available on WIX and other on-line services) lets you substitute standard icons for ProgMan's nearly useless default icon. With GrpIcon, for example, my Telecomm group is represented by a telephone pole icon; my Excel group sports Excel's own icon. If I want to open a group, I don't have to read a bunch of tiny labels to find the one I want; I just select them by icon, graphically, the way it should be.

Second, ProgMan should also allow groups within groups or folders within folders so you can set up nested hierarchies of groups. This would be a major improvement, letting you save space and have a more orderly and logical desktop. The Mac does this; so do NewWave and others.

Third, ProgMan should support virtual desktops larger than one screen. Microsoft ships TopDesk, a nice little bare-bones screen expander, with the Windows 3.1 Resource Kit. Why not build it into Windows itself? TopDesk isn't as slick as some of the commercial desktop expanders (WideAngle and all the rest), but it would at least provide a minimal functionality that's now simply absent.

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